**Obtaining federal funding can be complicated and tedious. It is a lengthy detailed process that requires patience and persistence.**

Photos courtesy of Jason Koss, Constructors Association of Western Pennsylvania

# AGC Cleans Up, Lowers Diesel Emissions

BY JAMIE IVES

**IT'S NOT EASY TO SECURE FEDERAL** funding to lower diesel emissions, but some AGC of America chapters would say it's worth it. Within the past five years, several chapters successfully applied for federal grants under the Environmental Protection Agency's (EPA's) National Clean Diesel Funding Assistance Program.

In fact, AGC and its chapters have done much more than any other construction association to persuade the EPA to allocate available retrofit funds to off-road construction equipment.

But, obtaining federal funding can be complicated and tedious. As those of you who have completed applications know, it is a lengthy detailed process that requires patience and persistence. On the plus side, the task is less onerous, when you have experience or you can work with those who have.

Here are the chapters victorious in their efforts to secure grants.

- Greater Florida members shared $1.6M with the Florida Refrigeration and Air Conditioning Contractors Association in 2010.
- Greater Milwaukee received $500,000 in 2010.
- Kentucky received $50,000 and $2M for grants awarded in 2007 and 2009.
- Minnesota members shared $3M and $977,243 for grants awarded to the Minnesota Environmental Initiative in 2009 and 2010.
- Constructors Association of Western Pennsylvania partnered with Allegheny County Health Department. They were awarded $1.25M in 2009.

In addition, many AGC members have benefited from funds awarded by the EPA to state and local agencies – indicating many public-private partnerships at play. The EPA grants were also a great asset for local businesses such as equipment dealers who performed the work.

## HOW THEY DID IT

### CONSTRUCTORS ASSOCIATION OF WESTERN PENNSYLVANIA

When the Constructors Association of Western Pennsylvania totalled their grant money and associated funds, they had $1.25 million. They used that money to help members repower or upgrade engines, or install diesel particulate filters on their off-road diesel equipment.

This was not the first time that Jason Koss, director of industry relations, had applied for a grant. In 2007, his hours of preparation came to naught. But in 2009, he and his associates took a different tact. "Leah Pilconis at the AGC of America got us started in the right direction, outlined a roadmap to follow, and was generally instrumental to receiving our grant."

Koss attended various workshops and joined the regional Diesel Collaborative. From these he learned the advantage of forming a team with complementary skills and similar goals. This was the case with the Allegheny County Health Department. Both wanted to lower emissions in heavily travelled areas throughout the region's air quality non-attainment zones.

Jason was fortunate to discover that the Allegheny County Health Department had grant application experience. "Typically there is a great deal of paperwork. They knew what to do and were not put off by the task. They also had regional air quality data that was needed to support the applications."

#### *WRENCH READY MACHINE LIST*

Another team member, the local equipment dealer Cleveland Brothers, also played a key role in providing additional grant details. Through its contact at Caterpillar Emissions Solutions, Cleveland Brothers was able to tell the association what machines would benefit from a retrofit, who owned the machines, and what parts would be needed to lower emissions.

Equally important, all the parts and changes were EPA approved or verified technology. Caterpillar's local and regional emissions specialists were also on hand to address any emission or

equipment concerns. Through seminars the association informed its members of the opportunity and sought their support.

With everything in place, the team was then able to send the EPA a detailed wrench-ready list of equipment, along with itemized costs for labor and parts. Once the money was received, everyone knew where to begin.

For the 26 engine repowers, the grant covered 75 percent of the cost with the members picking up the remaining 25 percent. For the 13 filters that were installed by another project partner, Ward Clean Air Products, the grant covered 100 percent of the cost. In total, 39 machines were retrofitted. They fell into six categories: bulldozers (D6, D8, and D9), graders, loaders, compactors, excavators, and paving machines.

### HOW EMISSIONS WERE LOWERED

The retrofit work was done according to what technical retrofits were available. For members, their workers, and the community, the changes made a great difference in the amount of particulate released into the air. The engine upgrade work took machines from unregulated to Tier 1. Benefits to engine repower work include lower maintenance, greater fuel economy, better performance, and extended life of the overall machine.

# HOW THEY DID IT

## AGC OF KENTUCKY

In 2009, AGC of Kentucky received $2 million in federal funds. That money was used to help its members lower diesel emissions and promote a reduced idling program at construction sites statewide. Participating AGC of Kentucky members also contributed another $513,458.43 in matching funds.

Carmen Grimm, director of finance, AGC of Kentucky, stated that the association sent its application in April 2009 and received the Notice of Award in August 2009.

During the application process and for the duration of administering the grant, she recalls the need for plenty of time. "We found out that we needed twice the amount of estimated time," says Grimm.

"There was a great deal of preparation. We held many meetings via teleconference as well as face-to-face meetings with unit owners and equipment dealers. To establish a fleet list, we canvassed members for a show of interest. We also held lengthy talks with equipment dealers to determine which members had eligible machines. Sometimes a technician would have to go out to a jobsite and run data logging to determine unit eligibility for grant participation and then assess further steps needed. Also, estimates had to be prepared for parts/labor/engine costs necessary for the repower or retrofit so that an initial cost budget could be prepared for the grant application."

## IT WAS EASY GOING GREEN

The folks at ECCO Equipment in Santa Ana, Calif. took their first big step many years ago when they started repowering some machines in their fleet with cleaner engines and implemented a no-idling policy. As a result of their efforts and their desire for continued improvement, they were recognized by the Association of Equipment Management Professionals (AEMP) in the fall of 2011 as being green fleet certified.

ECCO Equipment is a full-service rental company offering over 500 heavy earthmoving and watering equipment for the construction and mining industries. It operates out of 14 locations throughout the western U.S. and Canada, with AGC memberships in these states. ECCO is a family company and this year celebrates 50 years in the rental business.

Company president David Schmid is proud to be "ahead of the curve." When he learned that the AEMP had a green fleet certification program he was intrigued with the idea. "I estimated we were already close to qualifying, so I made the call."

The application process included a detailed inventory of the engine make, model, and tier of the company's, numerous off-road and on-road vehicles. It took about two weeks to collect the information and submit the application. "The AEMP is easy to work with," recalls Schmid. "We were pleased to learn that we would be recognized for what we had already put in place."

ECCO now holds a bronze level of certification. In the year ahead, Schmid's goal is to improve his company's standing to the silver level. "We are always upgrading our fleet by selling older machines and acquiring newer ones. We will just accelerate the process and be more strategic about the engine tier levels."

Schmid's goal for improvement appears founded in two strong traits. He is a practical businessman and he wants to do his part to improve air quality.

To stay competitive, he has to offer his clients late model equipment. That same equipment is cleaner running with lower emissions.

Based in Southern California, Schmid has a few opinions on smog. "Over the last several decades, air pollution has dropped significantly. It began with cleaner cars and is continuing with cleaner running tractors. We can look forward to that trend for many years to come and ECCO is pleased to be able to do our part."

He is also a great believer in putting limits on vehicle idling. "In the old days, machines idled for long periods of time to warm-up, to cool-down, and they idled all through lunch. Today, that's simply not necessary. Except for extreme environments, a few minutes of warm-up or cool-down are plenty. Just turn the key. Save money, save fuel, reduce noise, and lower emissions."

**In 2009, successful applicants AGC of Kentucky used their EPA grant money to upgrade their equipment and lower diesel emissions.**

## GREEN FLEET CERTIFICATION

AEMP
GREEN FLEET CERTIFIED

The Association of Equipment Management Professionals (AEMP) offers users of both on and off-road construction equipment the chance to receive Green Fleet certification. The program was created by the AEMP Emissions Committee to encourage the greening of fleets across the nation.

Through this program, the AEMP recognizes the steps a company has already taken to reduce emissions, offers incentives to companies willing to continue reducing emissions, and, by using the guidelines set by the California Air Resources Board, creates a "challenging, yet achievable goal for equipment owners to attain."

Michael Brennan, chairman of the AEMP Emissions Committee, states "there is added value at the bargaining table for companies who have taken steps to green their construction fleets. Our goal was to give these proactive fleet managers and their companies a competitive edge in the bidding process, as well as demonstrating their commitment to the environment across the nation."

### FOUR LEVELS OF ACHIEVEMENT FOR 2011-2012

- Bronze Status: 50 percent of fleet Tier 2 or written idle policy
- Silver Status: 50 percent of fleet Tier 2 and written idle policy
- Gold Status: 50 percent of fleet Tier 3 and written idle policy
- Platinum Status: 50 percent of fleet Tier 3, written idle policy, and 10 percent of fleet equipped with DPF, DOC or either interim or final Tier 4 technologies

### THE BENEFITS

Key benefits are improved fleet and industry perception among the public and all levels of government. Health is another benefit, including reduced absenteeism and improved morale and productivity. On the monetary side, voluntary green fleet investment helps fleets access federal funds to relieve costs associated with reducing emissions.

### THE PROCESS

On their website, AEMP offers an online application. Upon completion, the application is reviewed and your green fleet achievement level is determined. For more information contact Sara Sanderman, vice president of program development, at sara@aemp.org.

**To build on the public's overall support for its reduced idling program, AGC of Kentucky purchased a number of banners and used them at construction sites across the state to gain positive media coverage.**

### *COORDINATION / LOGISTICS*

Coordination of equipment and service work was a demanding task.

"We had to determine when units could be off their current jobsite and available for servicing. We then had to coordinate work time at the equipment dealer, allow time for parts and/or engines to be ordered so they were on hand when the unit was ready for service. And then we had to monitor the completion time of the service work so that the units would be ready in time to go back to the jobsite for the next scheduled project. Once the work was finished and the final invoice was generated, then the member would remit their match to the equipment dealer and then AGC of Kentucky would draw down the federal funds and remit final payment. In total, we had 40 repowers and 16 retrofits."

Throughout the process EPA wanted detailed quarterly status reports on money paid and work done. AGC of Kentucky had wisely left some monies unassigned to specific units just in case of cost overruns, of which there were only a few. After all the initial fleet list work had been done, some additional monies remained. AGC of Kentucky then used these final funds to assist other members to participate in the grant.

### *PUBLICITY*

AGC of Kentucky knew that good ideas sometimes go unnoticed. To let the community know how their association felt about lowering emissions it purchased 100 large vinyl banners announcing its reduced idling program. The banners were hung at various work sites of members who volunteered to sign a commitment to reduce idling, even if they did not get an upgrade. ◆

## CHECKLIST FOR GRANT APPLICATIONS

- Understand what the grant's goal or purpose is. Affirm that you have that capability.
- Seek guidance from those in your community with grant experience or from other AGC chapters or national headquarters.
- Form a team to complement your application.
- Allow more time than you think you will need.